Starting a Business in Tunisia: A Guide for Expats



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Starting a business in Tunisia offers a range of opportunities for expatriates looking to enter dynamic new markets, while benefiting from the unique

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sectoral opportunities, and essential **local resources** to ensure the success of your entrepreneurial project.

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Understanding the Available Legal Structures in Tunisia

Main Legal Structures for Business Creation in Tunisia:

Structure	Minimum Capital	Number of Partners	Liability	Management	N P P
Sole Proprietorship	None	1 (individual)	Unlimited (merging of assets)	Sole Proprietor	D c e b li r v r

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Structure	Minimum Capital	Number of Partners	Liability	Management	
Single-Member LLC (SUARL)	1,000 TND	1 (individual or legal entity)	Limited to contributions	Managing Partner	
Public Limited Company (SA)	5,000 TND	7 minimum	Limited to contributions	Board of Directors/Executive Board	

Main Characteristics and Distinctions:

- **Sole Proprietorship**
  - *Simplified procedure*, no share capital, management and liability borne by the sole proprietor

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- Most common form, suitable for SMEs.
- Low minimum capital (1,000 TND), up to 50 partners.
- Partners' liability limited to their contributions.
- Transfer of shares requires partner approval.
- Flexible operation, managed by one or more managers.
- Taxation: Corporate Tax or Income Tax based on profit distribution.

Single-Member Limited Liability Company (SUARL)

- Variant of the LLC for a single partner.
- Liability limited to the contribution.
- Allows isolation of the project holder's personal assets.
- Only one SUARL allowed per individual.

Public Limited Company (SA)

- Intended for large companies or projects requiring fundraising.
- Higher minimum capital (5,000 TND), at least 7 shareholders.
- Liability limited to the contribution.
- Complex governance: board of directors or executive board.
- Freely negotiable shares, possibility of stock market listing.

Summary Comparison:

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Criterion	Sole Proprietorship	LLC / SUARL	Public Limited Company (SA)
Required Capital	None	1,000 TND	5,000 TND
Number of Partners	1	1 (SUARL), 2-50 (LLC)	7 minimum
Decision-Making Process	Sole proprietor alone	Decisions by partners	General Assembly, Board of Directors
Flexibility	Very high	High	Less flexible, formalistic
Taxation	Income Tax	Corporate Tax or Income Tax	Corporate Tax

Registration Procedures (Common to Companies):

- Drafting of the bylaws.
- Filing of the bylaws and formalities with the commercial court registry.
- Publication of a notice of incorporation in a legal announcements newspaper.
- Registration with the National Business Registry (RNE).
- Opening a professional bank account

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unlimited liability represents a significant asset risk.

- **SUARL**: recommended form for entrepreneurs wanting to start alone while protecting their personal assets.
- **LLC (SARL)**: ideal for projects with trusted partners, offering flexibility and risk limitation.
- **Public Limited Company (SA)**: to be preferred for large-scale projects requiring fundraising or solid capital structuring.
- For expatriates, it is advisable to be assisted by a specialized firm to ensure compliance of procedures and proper drafting of bylaws.

Concrete Examples of Foreign Entrepreneurs:

- *Sole Proprietorship*: a French artisan settles in Tunis to launch a ceramics workshop, chooses sole proprietorship for administrative simplicity and direct management.
- *SUARL*: an Italian entrepreneur launches a digital consulting business, opts for SUARL to limit liability while remaining the sole decision-maker.
- *LLC (SARL)*: two German partners create a tech startup, choose the LLC to share capital, distribute management roles, and secure their investment.
- *Public Limited Company (SA)*: a group of Franco-Tunisian investors founds an industrial company, structures the project as a Public Limited Company to accommodate multiple shareholders and consider a future stock market listing.

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In Tunisia, the LLC is suitable for small and medium-sized enterprises with a minimum share capital of 1000 dinars, while the Public Limited Company requires a minimum capital of 300,000 dinars and offers management by a board of directors; sole proprietorships are simpler but involve unlimited personal liability. For expatriates, it is often recommended to consult a local advisor to align the chosen structure with the project's specific objectives and resources.

Administrative Procedures for Launching Your Business as an Expatriate

Main Administrative Steps to Launch a Business in Tunisia as an Expatriate

1 Obtaining Entry Visa and Residence Permit

- The expatriate must obtain a **business visa** from the Tunisian consulate in their home country.
- After arrival, it is necessary to apply for a **residence card** from the foreign police in Tunisia, justifying a local address and professional reason (business creation).
- To engage in professional activity, a **work permit** may be required depending on the sector.

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3 Defining the Registered Office

- Sign a **lease agreement** or **domiciliation contract** (mandatory registered office).
- Register this contract with the tax office to obtain proof of registered office.

4 Drafting and Registration of Bylaws

- Draft the company's **bylaws** (name, registered office, business purpose, capital, management).
- Have them reviewed by a professional (lawyer, accountant).
- Register the bylaws with the **Tax Office** (fixed fees, 24-hour procedure).

5 Opening a Professional Bank Account

- Provide the bylaws, the manager's residence card, and the bank form.
- Deposit the share capital.
- Obtain a bank certificate for registration.

6 Registration and Obtaining the Tax Identification Number

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- Register the company and employees with the **National Social Security Fund (CNSS)**.
- Provide the staff list and registration proofs.

8 Declaration to the Labor Inspectorate

- Perform an **establishment declaration**.
- The inspectorate may visit the premises for verification.

9 Manufacturing the Company Seal

- Order a customized seal from an authorized manufacturer.
- Provide the commercial register extract and the residence card.

Step	Main Detail	Key Document Required
Visa & Residence Permit	Procedures with consulate and foreign police	Passport, proof of address
Name Reservation	RNE Portal	Reservation Certificate
Registered Office	Lease or domiciliation	Registered Contract

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Step	Main Detail	Key Document Required
Registration & Taxation	RNE file submission, obtaining tax ID, identification card	RNE Extract, Business License
Social Security	CNSS Affiliation	Staff List, Residence Card
Labor Inspectorate	Establishment Declaration	Form, RNE Extract
Company Seal	Manufacturing official seal	RNE Extract, Residence Card

Legal and Tax Framework Specific to Foreigners

Foreigners can freely create a company, except in certain regulated sectors (defense, media, etc.) or those requiring specific authorizations.
Tax Regime: Companies benefit from tax advantages depending on the sector (export, ICT, industry, etc.) and location (regional development zones).
The formalities are identical to those for nationals, but the residence card and proof of residence are mandatory for registration.

Specific Restrictions or Advantages

Certain sectors are reserved for Tunisians or require majority Tunisian participation.
Access to tax advantages (exemptions, investment incentives) through the

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Business Incubators (Flat6Labs, B@Labs, Wiki Startup) offering mentorship, workspaces, and access to the local ecosystem.
One-Stop Shops (API, APII, RNE) to centralize and expedite procedures.
Specialized Advisors and Firms: tailored legal, tax, and administrative support.

Practical Tips to Facilitate Setup

- Be assisted by a local accountant or lawyer from the project conception phase.
- Prepare a complete and compliant file (bylaws, proof of address, residence card).
- Prioritize one-stop shops to save time.
- Inform yourself about sector-specific particularities and available incentives.
- Connect with networks of expatriate entrepreneurs to benefit from experiences and concrete feedback.

Good to Know:
Remember to obtain an investor visa and work permit before reserving a trade name and registering your company with the Tunisian Commercial Register; the local tax framework offers advantages to foreign investors, but check specific restrictions. Chambers of commerce and incubators in Tunisia are excellent resources to guide you through the process and help you integrate quickly into the local entrepreneurial fabric.

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An expatriate is considered a Tunisian tax resident if they stay more than 183 days per year in Tunisia, if their main home is there, or if they conduct their principal activity there. In this case, they are taxed on their worldwide income. A non-resident is only taxed on their Tunisian-source income.

Applicable Tax Rates

Type of Income or Activity	Tax Rate in 2025
Personal Income Tax	Progressive scale up to 35%
Corporate Tax (standard rate)	15% to 25% depending on activity and legal form
Corporate Tax – specific sectors (banks, oil)	35%
Corporate Tax – exporting companies	10% (or temporary exemptions)
VAT	18% (general rate)

Flat-rate or reduced regimes exist for certain sectors like crafts, agriculture, or projects in regional development zones.

Tax Treaties and Double Taxation

Tunisia has signed numerous bilateral tax treaties, notably with France, to avoid double taxation. These treaties determine in which country income should be taxed and provide mechanisms for tax credit or exemption to prevent the same

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years).

- Reduced Corporate Tax rates (10% to 15%) for certain activities and in regional development zones.
- Reduction of Corporate Tax rate to 20% for five years for companies listed on the Tunis Stock Exchange.
- Specific deductions for projects related to youth employment, agriculture, or innovation.

Financial Management Challenges for Expatriate Businesses

Currency Management: Foreign currency operations are strictly regulated. International fund transfers require justifications and the opening of foreign currency or convertible dinar accounts.

Opening Local Bank Accounts: Opening a professional bank account is mandatory for any company. Procedures can be lengthy and require presentation of legalized documents and justification of fund origin.

Financial Reporting Obligations: Quarterly and annual tax declarations (Corporate Tax, VAT, Personal Income Tax), obligation to maintain accounting compliant with Tunisian standards, payment of provisional installments, and annual results declaration.

Practical Tips and Useful Resources

- **Engage a local accountant**: to ensure compliance of tax declarations and accounting.

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- **Inquire with international banks present in Tunisia** to facilitate currency management and account opening.
- **Participate in expatriate entrepreneur networks** (UFE, CCI, business clubs) to benefit from experience sharing and information on best practices.

Key Resources for Tax Optimization and Financial Management

Resource	Main Usefulness
Tunisian Ministry of Finance	Official information on taxation
Tunisian Order of Chartered Accountants	Find a certified accountant
Chambers of Commerce (Franco-Tunisian, etc.)	Administrative and tax support
International Banks (Société Générale, UBCI...)	Banking services adapted for expatriates
Expatriate Entrepreneur Networks (UFE, CCI)	Experience sharing and practical information

Key Takeaways

Tunisian taxation is competitive and offers attractive incentives for foreign investors, but financial management requires good anticipation of obligations and adaptation to local specificities. Professional assistance is highly

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consult a specialized tax advisor to comply with Tunisian reporting obligations.

Access to Funding and Support Resources for International Startups

Expatriate entrepreneurs in Tunisia have a range of funding, support, and networking opportunities, fostered by local legislation and proactive economic policies.

Main Funding Opportunities for Expatriates:

- Public and private investment funds dedicated to innovation (e.g., Innovation Support Fund, “ANAVA” Fund denominated in foreign currency).
- Grants and loans adapted for startups, notably through the Greentech Tunisia program or the Startup Act, which offer tax and administrative advantages facilitating access to funding.
- Venture capital and local and international business angel investment.
- Access to international funding (European funds, international donors, EU4Business, African Development Bank).
- Specific bank loans: several Tunisian banks offer financing solutions for foreign entrepreneurs, with products dedicated to business creation and innovation.

Comparative Table of Funding Mechanisms

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Mechanism	Type	Indicative Amount	Target Audience	Specificity for Foreigners
Startup Act	Grant, Loan, Exemption	Variable	Labeled Startups	Facilitated access, tax advantages
Bank Loans	Loan	Project-dependent	Entrepreneurs	Dedicated products, simplified review
EU4Business	Grant, Support	Variable	SMEs, Startups	Open to foreigners
Business Angels	Investment	Variable	Early-stage Startups	International networks

Incubators and Accelerators Supporting International Startups:

- 216 Capital Venture Accelerator: 6-month program, mentorship, international coaching, minimum investment ticket of €50,000, integration into the Plug and Play network, access to global investors and partners.
- Flat6Labs Tunis: funding, coworking space, mentorship, training, internationalization support.
- B@Labs: support, access to experts, training workshops, collaborative

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- Modern coworking spaces
- Specialized training programs (pitching, strategy, financial management)
- Networking with investors, mentors, and local/international partners
- Access to events (conferences, summits, networking workshops)

Networking Initiatives and Key Events:

- Tunisian Startups Conference
- Startup Tunisia Summit
- Networking platforms like F6S or EU4Business
- Diaspora/local entrepreneur pairing programs

Examples of Success from Foreign Entrepreneurs or International Startups in Tunisia:

- **DabaDoc**: founded by an expatriate, raised $1M from Wamda Capital and Carthage Business Angels, expansion in North Africa.
- **E-Ship**: funded by Flat6Labs Tunis and EU4Business, regional development in logistics.
- **Instadeal**: raised funds from Carthage Business Angels and private investors, rapid growth in the Tunisian market and international expansion.

Influence of Legislation and Economic Policies:

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- Current economic policies aim to position Tunisia as a transregional innovation hub, with an ecosystem ranked in the Top 20 worldwide in 2025.

List of Main Local Financial Institutions Open to Foreigners:

- Banque de Tunisie
- Amen Bank
- BIAT (Banque Internationale Arabe de Tunisie)
- Attijari Bank

These banks offer products dedicated to business creation, innovation, and support for foreign entrepreneurs.

In Summary:

Expatriates wishing to create or develop a startup in Tunisia benefit from a favorable legislative environment, multiple funding sources, structured support from incubators and accelerators, and numerous networking and international growth opportunities.

> **Good to Know**:
> International startups in Tunisia can benefit from special government grants and adapted loans through local financial institutions like Amen Bank, and find support in incubators such as Flat6Labs, which offer mentorship, coworking, and networking connections with investors.

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Cyril Jarnias is an independent expert in international wealth management with over 20 years of experience. As an expatriate himself, he is dedicated to helping individuals and business leaders build, protect, and pass on their wealth with complete peace of mind.

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Thanks to his expertise, he offers sound advice to optimize his clients' wealth management. Cyril Jarnias is also recognized for his appearances in many prestigious media outlets such as BFM Business, les Français de l'étranger, Le Figaro, Les Echos, and Mieux vivre votre argent, where he shares his knowledge and know-how in wealth management.

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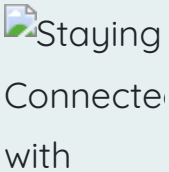
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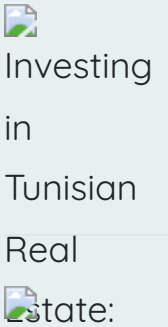


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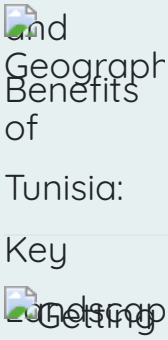
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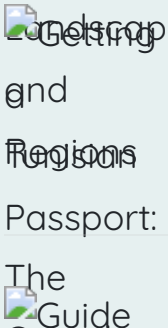
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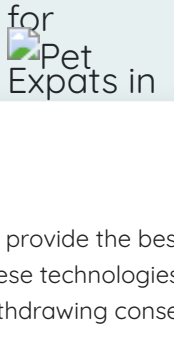
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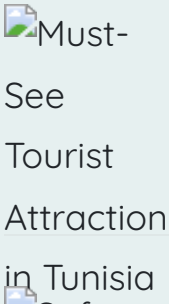


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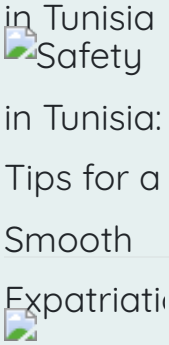
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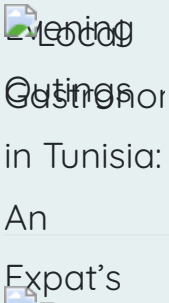
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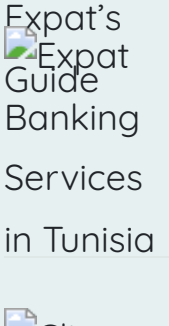
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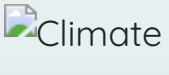
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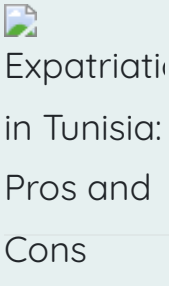


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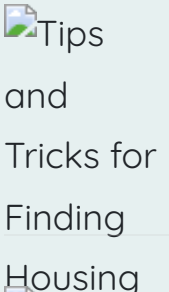
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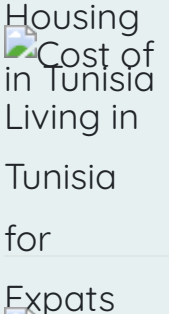
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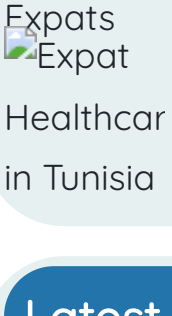
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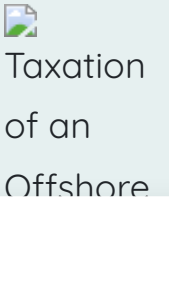
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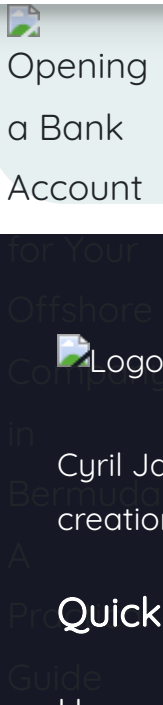
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